

8. **Buick** (4.3 percent). The Le Sabre and Park Avenue models were found to be most popular.

9. **A two-way tie: Nissan and Volvo** (2.9 percent each). The most popular Nissan is the Pathfinder sports utility vehicle; for Volvo, it is the 200 Series.

10. **A two-way tie: Chrysler, Jaguar** (2.7 percent each).

Other popular makes include Dodge, BMW, Mazda, Saab, Infiniti, Mercury, Acura, Honda, GMC, Volkswagen, Land Rover, Subaru, Pontiac, Audi, Isuzu, Plymouth, and Mitsubishi. The top three manufacturers are General Motors Corporation, with approximately 26.7 percent of the millionaire population; Ford Motor Company, with 19.1 percent; and Chrysler, with about 11.8 percent. As you can see, most millionaires are driving so-called Detroit metal. Most Americans who own motor vehicles also drive Detroit metal. How then can you tell if your neighbor who is driving a Ford, a Cadillac, or a Jeep is a millionaire or not? You can't. It's not easy to judge the wealth characteristics of people by the motor vehicles they drive.

An increasing number of affluent people are purchasing vehicles produced by American manufacturers, especially Buicks, Cadillacs, Chevrolets, Chryslers, Fords, Lincolns, and Oldsmobiles. This trend is related to the growing popularity of sports utility vehicles produced by Chrysler, Ford, and General Motors. What is it about Detroit metal that appeals to the wealthy? We can answer that question by reflecting on something that took place more than fifteen years ago.

After interviewing a group of ten millionaires, we walked into the parking lot of the research facility. We were very surprised to see that almost all of the millionaires we had just interviewed were driving full-sized Detroit metal, including Buicks, Fords, and Oldsmobiles. We looked at each other; one said: "These people are not into status; they buy automobiles by the pound!"

It's true. Many American millionaires have a propensity to purchase full-sized automobiles that have a low cost per pound. The average per pound price for all new motor vehicles is \$6.86. The full-sized Buick four-door sedan currently sells for less than \$6.00 a pound; the Chevrolet Caprice, about \$5.27 per pound; the Ford Crown Victoria, about \$5.50; the Lincoln Town Car, less than \$10.00 a pound; and the Cadillac Fleetwood, \$8.26 a pound. The Ford Explorer sells for about \$5.98 a